

Desert

Deserts are places of extremes.

Besides being dry, they experience intense sunshine, and a greater daily temperature range than any other land habitat. Rain—when it comes—typically falls in brief but torrential downpours, while strong winds pick up sand and grit, carrying it almost horizontally through the air. Although no 2 deserts are identical, true desert is usually defined as having less than 6 in (15 cm) of rainfall a year. Semidesert has more rainfall—up to 16 in (40 cm) a year—which typically falls during a relatively short spring or wet season followed by months of drought.

True desert

Most of the world's true desert is found in 2 belts, one straddling each of the tropics. Here, zones of high atmospheric pressure persist for months at a time, preventing low-pressure air from bringing in rain. Desert also forms where mountains block rain-bearing winds, and where cold, coastal currents chill the air so that it carries very little moisture inland.

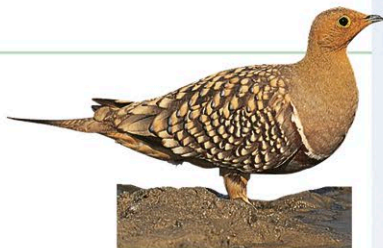
In true desert, the amount of rain is so meager, and so unpredictable, that very few plants can survive. The ones that do—such as cacti and other succulents—are highly effective at collecting and conserving what little water nature provides: they have large networks of shallow roots, which drain the surrounding ground so thoroughly that, often, nothing else can grow near by.

For animals, this arid environment creates some interesting effects. With so few plants, there is very little soil, which severely limits invertebrate life. Most

TRUE DESERT occurs at midlatitudes in the northern and southern hemispheres, and it can have less than 2 in (5 cm) of rain a year.

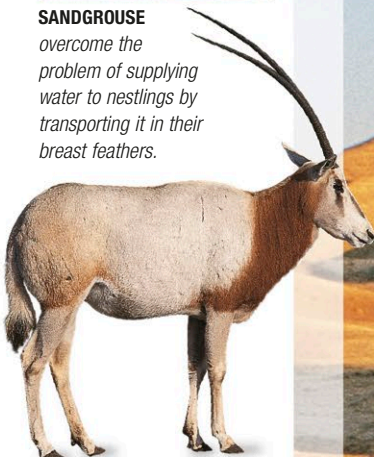
small animals, such as insects, are found either on the plants themselves or in the debris that accumulates immediately beneath them. Larger animals, such as reptiles and rodents, venture away from these pockets of greenery, but even they have to be careful to avoid the worst of the daytime heat.

Lack of vegetation means that most of the ground is exposed. Bare ground absorbs warmth very quickly when the sun rises, and reradiates it once the sun has set. The dry air accentuates this effect, allowing daytime surface temperatures to soar to over 158°F (70°C). As a result, most animals living in true desert are active after dark. During the day, they hide away, leaving little sign of themselves other than their tracks.



SANDGROUSE

overcome the problem of supplying water to nestlings by transporting it in their breast feathers.



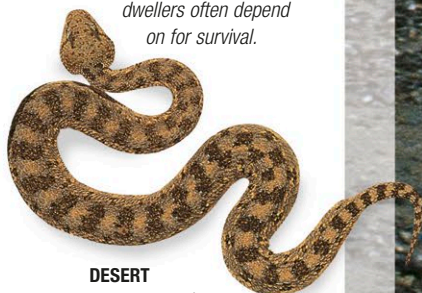
THE SCIMITAR-HORNED ORYX, like other nondrinkers, can get all the water it needs from its food.



THE FENNEC FOX is the smallest member of the dog family and survives in the Sahara and Sahel regions of Africa.



THE THORNY DEVIL has protective spines in addition to the good camouflage that other slow-moving ground dwellers often depend on for survival.



DESERT

SNAKES, such as the desert horned viper, will pursue their prey into their burrows.



COUCH'S SPADEFOOT TOAD is one of the desert frogs and toads that spend most of their lives underground.

